



Gender Roles in the Harry Potter Novels

Könsroller i Harry Potter-böckerna

Jakob Gustafsson

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Supervisor: Åke Bergvall

Examiner: Elisabeth Wennö

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Abstract

The very successful *Harry Potter* novels depict a magical society that is vastly different from the world of the reader. However, it becomes clear that the world of *Harry Potter* contains many of the same societal issues associated with traditional gender roles. The essay aims to show how the novels depict traditional gender roles by first highlighting the different ways that these gender roles make the magical society largely favour men while oppressing women. The magical society is shown to consider women irrational, favour men as leaders, highlight men as superior through its educational system and view women as weak individuals who need to be protected by men. The essay then moves on to explain how the character of Hermione Granger opposes and contradicts each of these norms, thus, ultimately showing that the *Harry Potter* novels undermine traditional gender roles.

Sammanfattning

De mycket framgångsrika *Harry Potter*-böckerna skildrar en magisk värld som skiljer sig mycket från läsarens. Det finns dock tecken på att det magiska samhället är präglad av många liknande problem associerade med traditionella könsroller som finns i läsarens värld. Målet med den här uppsatsen är att visa hur traditionella könsroller skildras i *Harry Potter*-böckerna genom att först synliggöra hur dessa könsroller gör att män gynnas medan kvinnor förtrycks i det magiska samhället. Analysen visar att det magiska samhället upprätthåller traditionella könsroller genom att kvinnor ses som irrationella, män ses som naturliga ledare, skolsystemet lyfter fram män som överlägsna samt att kvinnor ses som svaga individer som behöver bli beskyddade av män. Uppsatsen demonstrerar sedan hur karaktären, Hermione Granger, utmanar och motbevisar dessa normer vilket leder till slutsatsen att *Harry Potter*-böckerna i slutändan står i opposition till traditionella könsroller.

Since J.K Rowling released the first entry in the *Harry Potter* novels in 1997, the series has become a cultural phenomenon on a level that few other book series has managed to achieve. The fictional world of the *Harry Potter* series depicts a magical society that exists parallel to a fictional ‘real world’ with its own government and educational system. However, even though this society is vastly different from the fictional world, there are still similarities to the world of the reader when it comes to the depiction of traditional gender roles in the novels.

Some previous research on this topic suggests that traditional gender roles are indeed an important aspect of the novels. For instance, Amy Billone poses the question, “Do the Harry Potter books ultimately eliminate gender stereotypes, or radically enforce them?” and her answer is: “I believe that Rowling inscribes this question within her stories themselves” (198). This view on the topic is important to keep in mind when analysing the Harry Potter novels as the texts may, in fact, problematise the issue of traditional gender roles.

The aim of this essay is to examine how gender roles are portrayed in the *Harry Potter* series with *Order of the Phoenix* and *Half-Blood Prince* as the basis of the analysis. Since the novels may show different perspectives on gender roles, the essay looks closer at the characters and social structures of the world of *Harry Potter* by highlighting examples that either undermine or enforce traditional gender roles. Based on the analysis, I argue that the *Harry Potter* series undermine traditional gender roles through the character of Hermione Granger, who both challenges and contradicts the norms of these gender roles that are present in the magical society.

Before analysing the texts, I will define traditional gender roles. Lois Tyson describes how there is a difference in the way that men and women are perceived in terms of their traits: “*Traditional gender roles* cast men as rational, strong, protective, and decisive; they cast women as emotional (irrational), weak, nurturing, and submissive” (81). To further elaborate on how women are viewed as emotional and irrational, Tyson mentions that patriarchy, for example, uses hysteria which “refers to psychological disorders deemed peculiar to women and characterized by overemotional, extremely irrational behaviour”, and that “These gender roles have been used very successfully to justify inequities, which still occur today, such as excluding women from equal access to leadership and decision-making positions” (81).

Just as patriarchy works to define women as overemotional and irrational, the same ideas exist in the magical world of Harry Potter. An example of how the novels differentiate between men and women in this manner can be seen by comparing the characters of Arthur Weasley and his wife, Molly Weasley. During the events of *Order of the Phoenix*, Arthur and

Molly has a heated argument with their son, Percy. One of their other sons, Fred, tells Harry Potter that ““every time Percy’s name’s mentioned, Dad breaks whatever he’s holding and Mum starts crying”” (Rowling, *Order* 65). While this description shows both characters having an emotional reaction, the way the other characters describe Molly Weasley seems to point to her as being the irrational one. In the same interaction, Ron Weasley says ““Mum’s been in a right state”” and ““You know – crying and stuff”” (Rowling, *Order* 67). Ron seems to be saying that his mother’s mental health has declined since the fight with Percy because of her excessive crying. However, Ron makes no mention of Arthur Weasley being unwell, even though Fred mentions that he has been breaking things in his emotional outbursts. None of the other characters makes any mentions in this exchange about Arthur having emotional issues. The fact that only Molly and not Arthur is described as being in a bad mental state seems to point to the values of traditional gender roles in the magical society. Ron only shows concerns for his mother’s mental health because he does not see his father’s behaviour as irrational as seems to be the case with Molly and this is not isolated to this particular text. In *Half-Blood Prince*, Ron once again emphasizes the difference between his mother and father as Ron recalls how he and his brothers got into trouble once: ““He went mental,’ said Ron, with a reminiscent gleam in his eyes. ‘Only time I’ve ever seen Dad as angry as Mum’” (Rowling, *Prince* 271-72). What is most striking about Ron’s words is how the one time that Arthur is described as mental, he immediately makes a comparison between him and Molly as if this kind of behaviour is expected of her. Yet, as shown with the example of Arthur breaking things, he too exhibits signs of what could be considered emotional behaviour. However, Ron seems to think that there is a difference between his parents’ actions which could be attributed to Ron being influenced by traditional gender roles. Molly clearly falls victim to the problematic aspects of the ideas that traditional gender roles enforce, and, in fact, she is not the only female character affected.

These views on women being overemotional can also be seen in the way that Harry describes them. When he goes on a date with Cho Chang, Cho becomes upset and starts crying which eventually leads to her leaving Harry at the café they are visiting (Rowling, *Order* 519). Afterwards, Harry leaves and expresses his frustration about the situation: ““Women!’ he muttered angrily” and also adds ““Why does she always want to drag up a subject that makes her act like a human hosepipe?”” (Rowling, *Order* 520). The first indicator that Harry is influenced by traditional gender roles is the fact that he exclaims “women”. Instead of just being frustrated with Cho, he implies that there is a general problem with women being emotional that is the cause of the situation he is in. The second indicator is the

description of Cho as “a human hosepipe” which clearly is an exaggeration of how much she is crying. Since he seems to blame women in general in this situation, his description of “a human hosepipe” seems to reflect his view of all women within the magical society. Ron also seems to think that Cho is being irrational in this situation as he conveys to Hermione: “‘You should write a book,’ Ron told Hermione as he cut up his potatoes, ‘translating mad things girls do so boys can understand them’” (Rowling, *Order* 530). In this exchange, Ron makes it clear that he thinks that women are too emotional and that men are the rational ones who are bothered by the behaviour of women. The fact that both Ron and Harry behave in this manner seems to point to the fact that it is not just individual characters who enforce traditional gender roles but rather that there is a consensus on this in the society they live in. In fact, this belief is so strong that some male characters are afraid of being seen as irrational themselves. Lauren R. Camacci describes one instance where Draco Malfoy is caught being emotional by Harry: “Harry sees him acting ‘unmanly’, which is embarrassing and, moreover, dangerous, for Harry could tell other students, who would then judge Malfoy as ‘unmanly’, thereby ruining his reputation” (34). With this example, Camacci demonstrates how traditional gender roles are doing just as much harm to the male characters in Harry Potter as the female ones.

Another patriarchal issue is the process of denying women powerful positions in society, and this too is present in the society of Harry Potter. While there are a few women with a great deal of influence, such as Dolores Umbridge who becomes High Inquisitor at the magic school of Hogwarts, the most powerful social positions are otherwise held by men. And the exception of Umbridge seems to prove the general rule since she turns out to be such a problematic leader. For most of the Harry Potter novels, Albus Dumbledore is the headmaster. However, during the events of *Order of the Phoenix*, he is forced to flee the school and abandon his post as headmaster (Rowling, *Order* 574-75). After he leaves, Dolores Umbridge becomes headmaster at Hogwarts. On the one hand, this leaves her in an equal position to Dumbledore when it comes to influence and power. It can even be argued that “Dolores Umbridge affects the plot of *Order of the Phoenix* in important ways, managing to undermine Dumbledore’s authority at Hogwarts more successfully than any of his male enemies” (Pugh and Wallace, 269). On the other hand, it should be noted that this position is given to her by a man since the decree that declare Umbridge headmaster is signed by the minister of magic, Cornelius Fudge. It is possible that the ministry of magic always delegates the position of headmistress and headmaster at Hogwarts, which would not make it strange for Umbridge, as a woman, to be given such a powerful position by a man. However, this is unlikely for two reasons. First, it seems that Hogwarts as an institution works independently of the ministry of

magic. During the sorting ceremony at the beginning of the fifth novel, Umbridge gives a speech about her new role at the school (Rowling, *Order* 196-97). Hermione later explains the meaning of the speech to Ron and Harry by saying: “‘It means the Ministry’s interfering at Hogwarts’” (Rowling, *Order* 198). This seems to imply that the ministry has not had a great deal of influence over the school in the past, which in turn means that the only time a woman is a headmistress in the novels, a man has handed her that position in the first place. The second piece of evidence that points to men having easier access to the role of headmaster or headmistress at Hogwarts can be found by examining how Dumbledore regains his role as headmaster. Towards the end of the novel, he returns after being wanted by the ministry, and confronts Fudge. When speaking with Fudge, Dumbledore again showcases the lack of authority that the ministry has over him and reinstates himself as headmaster without any authorisation by Fudge (Rowling, *Order* 754). In fact, not only does he retake his old position, but he also gives orders to Fudge regarding Hogwarts, which gives the impression that Dumbledore is the one who is really in charge: “‘You will give the order to remove Dolores Umbridge from Hogwarts’” (Rowling, *Order* 753). By this point, Umbridge has not only been given a role of power by a man but has also had the very same role taken away in an instant by a man. The way that the men in Harry Potter give and take away power from women highlight the extent to which the traditional gender roles are represented in the magical society, both in the ministry of magic as in the case with Fudge and in the educational system in the case with Dumbledore.

Another instance where a man is naturally elected to be the leader of a group can be seen in the founding of “Dumbledore’s Army” or “DA” for short. As a result of the ministry interfering at Hogwarts, the students are not allowed to use magic in the Defence Against the Dark Arts classes and have to read theory books instead. In response to this, Hermione suggests: “‘Well – learn Defence Against the Dark Arts ourselves’” (Rowling, *Order* 301). Even though Hermione provides the idea for what eventually becomes “DA”, she is not considered as a candidate for leadership of “DA”. Instead, it is Harry who is eventually elected leader of the group (Rowling, *Order* 362). Hermione and Ron do give solid arguments for choosing Harry as a leader since he has battled against the dark arts on multiple occasions in the past (Rowling, *Order* 303). However, Harry mentions that Hermione has performed better in tests, which should at least qualify her for being considered a potential leader or perhaps for sharing the leadership with Harry. Nevertheless, the “DA” members seem to consider Harry as the only choice without Hermione or anyone else having a chance. In fact, when Hermione wants to determine the leader by having every member vote (Rowling, *Order*

362), she immediately gets interjected by Cho Chang: “‘Harry’s leader,’ said Cho at once, looking at Hermione as though she were mad” (Rowling, *Order* 362). Cho seems to think that it is absurd that anybody else than Harry could become leader, as illustrated by the way she looks at Hermione. Furthermore, neither Cho nor any member acknowledges Hermione’s skills in magic and even Hermione herself does not seem to recognize her abilities in this situation as she defends her suggestion of voting by saying: “‘It makes it formal and it gives him authority’” (Rowling, *Order* 362). In other words, Hermione seems to accept the fact that Harry is the natural leader of the group and that it is of no use to vote for anyone other than Harry Potter.

The idea of men as superior to women in the world of Harry Potter has found its way into the educational system as well. For example, when Umbridge starts teaching at Hogwarts, Hermione questions the new system for teaching Defence Against the Dark Arts (Rowling, *Order* 224-25). In response to Hermione’s objection, Umbridge says “Wizards much older and cleverer than you have devised our new programme of study” (Rowling, *Order* 225). It should be noted that by “Wizards”, Umbridge is referring to male magicians since the characters in Harry Potter use different words to differentiate between male and female magic users, with “witch” being used for the latter: “‘he would have had great power and influence over witches and wizards’” (Rowling, *Prince* 359). Thus, Umbridge’s response implies that only men were involved with the creation of the new educational system at Hogwarts which shows how men have more influence over the magical society than women. Umbridge also seems to emphasize the differences between Hermione and the wizards by telling her how “much older and cleverer” they are. Therefore, Umbridge may be enforcing the idea that men are at least smarter than women in this instance. Another teacher at Hogwarts also seems to share the mindset of Umbridge is Severus Snape. During one of Snape’s lessons, he holds a lecture about using magic without speaking. However, it is his choice of words that makes the situation similar to the one with Umbridge: “‘Not all wizards can do this, of course’” (Rowling, *Prince* 149). Once again, the word “wizards” is used, and Snape does not include “witches” in his statement. As with Umbridge, there is an implication in Snape’s words that makes it seem like men are favoured in the magical society of *Harry Potter* by choosing male terms over female ones. Snape’s statement might also imply that he thinks women are less likely to be able to perform advanced magic since he is choosing to refer only to male magic users in this instance.

The texts also show how men consider women weak and needing to be protected by them. For example, Ron, Dean Thomas, and Harry are all being protective of Ginny Weasley.

First, Ron tries to control Ginny by objecting to the way she behaves in public with her boyfriend, Dean (Rowling, *Prince* 238). Ginny tries to defend her right to do what she wants without needing Ron's approval. However, Ron responds with "'D'you think I want people saying my sister's a –'" (Rowling, *Prince* 239). While he does not finish the sentence, a word like "slut" or another offensive word is probably used based on the context of the situation as well as Ginny's reaction: "'A what?' shouted Ginny, drawing her wand" (Rowling, *Prince* 239). Despite Ginny making it clear that she can take care of herself, Ron seems concerned about her reputation and feels the need to protect her. Furthermore, Ron's actions in his relationship make it clear that he has different views on what is considered acceptable behaviour by men and women respectively. On the one hand, Ron lectures Ginny about not kissing her boyfriend in public and on the other, he does the same thing himself. When Harry is looking for Ron after a Quidditch match, he sees Ron and Lavender Brown being very intimate in a public place: "There, in full view of the whole room, stood Ron wrapped so closely around Lavender Brown it was hard to tell whose hand were whose" (Rowling, *Prince* 250). In this moment, Ron does not seem concerned about his own reputation despite the concern he showed for Ginny earlier in the novel. Ginny even points out that Ron is contradicting his own words: "'He's over there, the filthy hypocrite'" (Rowling, *Prince* 250). Like Ron, Dean is also being protective of Ginny. He even seems to think that Ginny is unable to perform the smallest of tasks as is illustrated when he tries to help Ginny climb through the portrait hole that the students use every day. Ginny also expresses her frustration with his behaviour: "'Don't push me, please, Dean,' she said, sounding annoyed. 'You're always doing that, I can get through perfectly well on my own'" (Rowling, *Prince* 398). With these words, she also implies that this kind of behaviour occurs frequently with Dean. Lastly, Harry is also trying to protect Ginny towards the end of *Half-Blood Prince*. When Harry realises that the people around him may be in danger, he becomes concerned about Ginny's safety and makes a decision about their relationship: "'We can't be together'" (Rowling, *Prince* 538). Once again, Ginny has to stand up for herself: "'What if I don't care?' said Ginny fiercely" (Rowling, *Prince* 538). While it may not be strange for Harry to worry about his girlfriend's safety, this is not the first time in the series that he acts as the strong protector of her. Karley Adney points out that in *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*, "his knowledge of her feelings for him causes him to behave in a typical masculine manner: he saves Ginny, the damsel in distress" (179). It seems that several years later during the events of *Half-Blood Prince*, Harry stills sees Ginny as "the damsel in distress" even though he has seen her ability to defend herself with his own eyes. For example, during the Death Eaters'

attack on Hogwarts, Ginny is able to battle a Death Eater on her own. Even though Harry aids Ginny in this battle, she does show that she can stand her ground against an adult wizard (Rowling, *Prince* 498). The way that these male characters treat Ginny as weak despite evidence pointing to the contrary, is a good example of how much patriarchy and traditional gender roles are encoded in the Harry Potter novels. While both Harry and Ron have been shown to enforce traditional gender roles, the fact that Dean also feels that he has to protect Ginny points to that this kind of behaviour is the norm in the magical society.

While it seems as if the magical society in Harry Potter enforces the idea that women behave irrationally, the character of Hermione Granger acts in a manner that seems to undermine this idea. First, however, it could be argued that the language of the texts portrays Hermione as being very emotional. For example, Maeve Eberhardt demonstrates how “[n]ot only is her use of *cry* notable for its overall occurrence, but also for the fact that its frequency rises throughout the series” (237). However, the texts may portray Hermione in this manner to show that just because someone is exhibiting emotion, it does not mean that they cannot also be rational. In fact, there are many instances where Hermione is acting in a very rational manner while a male character is behaving irrationally. For example, when Harry arrives at the headquarters of The Order, he lashes out at Hermione and Ron for not providing him with information during the summer. In fact, Harry becomes extremely angry as is indicated by the use of capital letters in the text: “‘WHO HAD TO GET PAST DRAGONS AND SPHINXES AND EVERY OTHER FOUL THING LAST YEAR?’” (Rowling, *Order* 61). In this moment, Hermione tries to calm him, and she seems calm since her lines are not capitalised: “‘Harry, we wanted to tell you, we really did –’ Hermione began” (Rowling, *Order* 61). However, Harry cannot control his emotions and interrupts Hermione in the middle of her answer: “‘CAN’T’VE WANTED TO THAT MUCH’” (Rowling, *Order* 61). Furthermore, Harry’s problem with his temper seems to be a recurring issue. When Harry has a vision of Sirius Black being tortured by Lord Voldemort, he wants to go to the ministry of magic and rescue Sirius (Rowling, *Order* 674). Since Sirius is Harry’s godfather, it makes sense that Harry should be unable to think straight in this situation, acting on emotion instead of thinking rationally. It is instead Hermione who has to object to the logic of Sirius being captured: “‘But this is just – just so *unlikely!*’ said Hermione desperately. ‘Harry, how on earth could Voldemort have got hold of Sirius when he’s been in Grimmauld Place all the time?’” (Rowling, *Order* 675). Additionally, despite Hermione giving a solid argument, Ron chooses to side with Harry (Rowling, *Order* 675), further cementing the idea that the men in Harry Potter see themselves as the rational ones. As it turns out, Hermione was actually right

in this situation, which becomes clear when Harry and his friends arrive at the ministry only to find that Sirius was never there (Rowling, *Order* 720). With this example, it is clear that Hermione as a character contradicts traditional gender roles as she applies logical thinking to a complicated situation. Furthermore, Harry's behaviour shows that men are just as capable of acting out of emotion and that it can be harmful to the people around them. In ignoring Hermione's advice, not only does Harry endanger the lives of his friend, but his actions also lead to Sirius's death (Rowling, *Order* 741-42).

In addition to undermining traditional gender roles by being rational herself, Hermione also protests against the male characters' view on women as irrational. For instance, after Harry's failed date with Cho, he cannot understand what he did wrong and he consults Hermione about it and she says "Well, I'm sorry, but you were a bit tactless" (Rowling, *Order* 528). However, Harry seems offended by the thought that he might be at least partly responsible for Cho leaving him: "Me, tactless?" said Harry, outraged" (Rowling, *Order* 528). Hermione does admit that "I'm not saying what she did was sensible" but does add "I'm just trying to make you see how she was feeling at the time" (Rowling, *Order* 529). The point that she is trying to get across seems to be that Cho may have acted emotionally, but that Harry must understand why she is feeling the way she does. In fact, Harry's lack of understanding may be part of the reason why he resorts to traditional gender roles by, for example, calling Cho "a human hosepipe". Hermione also tries to make Ron be more understanding of Cho since he clearly expresses how irrational he thinks Cho behaves: "What sort of person cries while someone's kissing them?" (Rowling, *Order* 424). When Hermione speaks of Cho, in contrast to Harry, she shows more empathy: "she's feeling very sad, because of Cedric dying. Then I expect she's feeling confused because she liked Cedric and now she likes Harry, and she can't work out who she likes best" (Rowling, *Order* 424). Instead of reducing Cho to "a human hosepipe", Hermione explains why it makes perfect sense that she is crying because of the emotional baggage she carries. However, despite Hermione providing several logical arguments, Ron is not convinced: "One person can't feel all that at once, they'd explode" (Rowling, *Order* 425). Ron's beliefs about women being emotional is so strong that he rejects Hermione's explanation, showing how much resistance she is up against, but despite this, Hermione does not give in and tells Ron "Just because you've got the emotional range of a teaspoon doesn't mean we all have" (Rowling, *Order* 425). The fact that Hermione defends Cho, even against her best friends, shows just how much Hermione disapproves of how traditional gender roles define women. In fact, as Sarah Margaret Kniesler describes it: "Hermione recognizes the boys' adherence to patriarchal

values. Instead of distancing herself from them or resigning herself to their latent prejudices against ‘Others,’ Hermione attempts to expose Harry and Ron to more open-minded views” (99).

Since most of the powerful positions in Harry Potter are dominated by men, the novels seem to enforce the idea that men possess certain leadership qualities that make them more suited to such positions than women. However, Hermione makes a good case for women’s ability to be a leader through her actions and attributes. Firstly, even though Harry becomes the leader of “DA”, Hermione is the one that takes the initiative before he is elected. During the meeting where the idea for “DA” is pitched, she is the one who greets the group and explains why “DA” should be formed in the first place (Rowling, *Order* 314). In the beginning, she does not seem confident in herself: “‘Er,’ said Hermione, her voice slightly higher than usual out of nerves” (Rowling, *Order* 314). However, she eventually becomes more relaxed and shows that she can overcome her nervousness and act as a temporary leader figure for the group: “(Hermione’s voice became suddenly much stronger and more confident)” (Rowling, *Order* 314). Her confidence at this moment is noteworthy since the members of “DA” seem to favour Harry from the start: “The group focused its attention on her instead, though eyes continued to dart back regularly to Harry” (Rowling, *Order* 314). As mentioned previously, Hermione seems to favour Harry as a leader as well. However, after some encouragement, she finds the courage to take credit for the concept of “DA” despite the group seemingly idolising Harry: “‘Harry here had the idea – I mean’ (Harry had thrown her a sharp look) ‘I had the idea’” (Rowling, *Order* 314). It is worth highlighting that her confidence in herself as leader is not something that occurs to her naturally, but she instead discovers it while organising “DA”. This seems to suggest that women in the magical society do, in fact, have to learn to recognise their leadership qualities while men take it for granted since they are considered to possess these qualities naturally. Even after Harry officially is elected leader, Hermione continues to be important for “DA”. Since the group is in danger of being disbanded if Umbridge discovers its existence, the group cannot speak openly about its meeting schedule. Hermione comes up with a solution to the problem by having the members use magic coins to communicate with each other (Rowling, *Order* 368-69). Despite not being officially acknowledged as a leader, she steps up when the group faces a problem and also solves that problem, thus becoming vital to the group’s continued operation.

Even though Hermione is not elected leader in “DA”, she is the head of an organisation of her own. During the events of the Harry Potter series, Hermione founds “The Society for the Promotion of Elfish Welfare”, S.P.E.W. for short, where she fights the oppression of

house elves. Although she is the sole member of the organisation, she does show that she takes her work in “S.P.E.W.” seriously and can handle the burden of the workload on her own. For example, in *Order of the Phoenix*, she makes clothes for the house elves working at Hogwarts and says “I did them over the summer. I’m a really slow knitter without magic but now I’m back at should be able to make lots more” (Rowling, *Order* 237). Despite not being able to use magic and not having any assistance, Hermione takes responsibility as leader of her organisation. Since it seems difficult for women in Harry Potter to acquire a high position, the texts may suggest that Hermione’s path of creating new organisations is the most viable option in the magic society, or in any society, for women who seek a position as a leader. Furthermore, Rivka Temima Kellner draws a connection between S.P.E.W. and the oppression of women: “Since house elves remind us so much of unemancipated women in chauvinist societies, it is no surprise that Hermione Granger, the central female protagonist in the ‘Harry Potter’ books, is bothered by the social injustices concerning the house elves” (370). With this in mind, the work Hermione performs in S.P.E.W. can be seen both as a way to show that women are capable of being in charge of an organisation as well as a way to oppose the ideologies of patriarchy.

Not only does Hermione show great leadership qualities in organisations, but she also exhibits the same qualities in her relationships. For example, Ron is relying heavily on Hermione when it comes to his education. In fact, he is unable to finish some of his assignments on his own: “there’s no point trying to finish this now, I can’t do it without Hermione” (Rowling, *Order* 237). Additionally, Ron leaves their prefect duties to Hermione which can be seen when she interrupts Fred and George from performing their experiments on students: “Ron rose halfway out of his chair, hovered uncertainly for a moment or two, then muttered to Harry, ‘She’s got it under control,’ before sinking as low in his chair as his lanky frame permitted (Rowling, *Order* 235). In these examples, Ron shows the confidence he has in Hermione’s abilities to both support him when he needs help as well as being able to handle difficult situations on her own. Besides helping Ron out, Hermione shows that she can act when Harry, who is usually the leader of the group, cannot protect them from danger. When Umbridge interrogates Harry, she decides that torture is the only way to get information out of him. At this moment, he seems unable to find a way out of the situation: “He closed the door behind him with a snap, leaving Harry in a state of worse turmoil than before: Snape had been his very last hope” (Rowling, *Order* 687). Just as Harry is about to be tortured, Hermione intervenes and manages to trick Umbridge into following them into the Forbidden Forest and only then are they able to escape (Rowling, *Order* 689-95). This shows that

Hermione can act as a leader even during the pressure of her friends being in danger. It also shows just how dependent Harry is on Hermione's abilities since he had lost all hope. In fact, Alexandra Hidalgo describes her as a kind of mother figure for Harry, whose mother, Lily, was murdered: "Hermione, as Dumbledore hoped, keeps Harry focused on destroying the Horcruxes, completing the work Lily began toward turning Harry into the sort of person who, like herself, is willing to die to protect those he loves" (70).

The educational system in Harry Potter has been shown to favour men in certain instances such as the previous examples with Umbridge and Snape. However, Hermione finds ways to go against the patriarchal ideologies that Umbridge and Snape seem to endorse. First, even though Umbridge tells Hermione that "Wizards much older and cleverer than you have devised our new programme of study" (Rowling, *Order* 225), it does not stop Hermione from questioning Umbridge (Rowling, *Order* 226). Despite Umbridge trying to undermine Hermione's effort, she does not give in. In fact, after Hermione's objection, other students start questioning the new course aims as well: "'We're not going to use magic?' Ron exclaimed loudly" (Rowling, *Order* 224). Hermione not only questions the new system set in place by the older wizards, but her protest also becomes the starting point for other students to express their opinions, thus, showing that just because older men designed the curriculum, it does not mean that it cannot be criticised, which seems to be Umbridge's main point.

As in the case with Umbridge, Snape's notion of witches being less likely to perform advanced magic is, once again, undermined by Hermione. First, her test results are a good indication that Hermione is a skilled magician. During the fifth year at Hogwarts, students take the O.W.L. exams in their respective subjects. These exams seem to be quite difficult, indicated by George Weasley's description of them: "'Half our year had minor breakdowns coming up to O.W.L.s,' said George happily. 'Tears and tantrums ... Patricia Stimpson kept coming over faint'" (Rowling, *Order* 210). Despite the difficulty of the exams, Hermione receives "nine 'Outstandings' and one 'Exceeds Expectations'" (Rowling, *Prince* 86), which are the highest and second-highest grades respectively that a student can be given in the O.W.L.s. Aside from the results in the O.W.L.s, Hermione contradicts Snape by showing that witches can be just as proficient in using advanced spells as wizards. In fact, she seems to be the only one in her class able to use these spells based on Harry's description of the lesson: "A reasonable amount of cheating ensued; many people were merely whispering the incantation instead of saying it aloud. Typically, ten minutes into the lesson Hermione managed to repel Neville's muttered Jelly-Legs Jinx without uttering a single word" (Rowling, *Prince* 150). However, Snape does not seem impressed by her performance: "a feat

that would surely have earned her twenty points for Gryffindor from any reasonable teacher, thought Harry bitterly, but which Snape ignored” (Rowling, *Prince* 150). This may also be another indicator that Snape favours wizards as he refuses to acknowledge Hermione’s success. Nevertheless, the fact that Hermione is able to use this advanced magic when “Not all wizards can do this” demonstrates the incredible skills that she possesses, thus, showing Snape that gender does not determine one’s magic competence.

While certain men in the texts act as if the women need to be protected by them, Hermione’s actions demonstrate that this is not the case. For example, Helen Berents points out that “Hermione’s willingness and ability to defend both herself and others (such as house elves) increases through the books and demonstrates her growing independence and agency” (149). A good example of her ability to do this can be seen during the train ride to Hogwarts in *Order of the Phoenix*. Malfoy enters the compartment of Harry and his friends and starts teasing him: “‘Tell me, how does it feel being second-best to Weasley, Potter?’” (Rowling, *Order* 179). In this moment, Hermione defends Harry and when Malfoy continues his teasing, she decides that she has had enough: “‘Get out!’ said Hermione, standing up” (Rowling, *Order* 179). Malfoy decides to heed Hermione’s command and leaves the compartment. First, this example shows Hermione’s strength as an independent woman by standing up to Malfoy without any help. Second, she also reverses the traditional gender roles by defending Harry since he has been shown to act protectively of female characters like Ginny. In this case, it is instead Harry who is defended by a female character.

Not only is Hermione’s strength evident in her abilities to defend others, but her strength is also shown in her ability to manipulate and outthink other characters. During the events of *Order of the Phoenix*. Harry claims that Lord Voldemort has returned which leads to articles in magazines like the *Daily Prophet* calling him a liar. In response to this, Hermione comes up with a plan to give Harry more credibility with the magical society. Hermione reveals to Harry that she has enlisted the famous reporter, Rita Skeeter, to write an article where he can speak freely about Voldemort’s return (Rowling, *Order* 523). However, it is also revealed that Hermione is blackmailing Rita into writing the article without any payment. When Rita protests, Hermione makes it clear who is in charge: “‘Well, yes,’ said Hermione calmly, taking a sip of her drink. ‘Otherwise, as you very well know, I will inform the authorities that you are an unregistered Animagus (Rowling, *Order* 525). It is clear that Hermione has a strong presence at this moment as is indicated by how Rita reacts to her words: “‘I don’t suppose I’ve got any choice, have I?’ said Rita, her voice shaking slightly” (Rowling, *Order* 525). What should also be noted is that Hermione plans and executes this

blackmail all on her own initiative since she leaves Harry and Ron without any explanation of what she is about to do (Rowling, *Order* 506). The way that Hermione handles this problem once again shows she can protect Harry from threats. Additionally, by singlehandedly blackmailing an adult woman, she makes it clear how much power she has over other characters.

Hermione further demonstrates her independence during Slughorn's Christmas party in *Half-Blood Prince*. At first, Hermione is planning to invite Ron as her guest to the party. However, Ron acts rudely since he has not been invited himself: "It's pathetic. Well, I hope you enjoy your party. Why don't you try getting off with McLaggen, then Slughorn can make you King and Queen Slug" (Rowling, *Prince* 234). Hermione becomes upset with his words and decides not to invite him (Rowling, *Prince* 235). Instead of going to the Christmas without a male date, Hermione later reveals that she is going to the party with Cormac McLaggen instead (Rowling, *Prince* 260). McLaggen himself is described as a strong male figure indicated by his personality: "We met on the train, in old Sluggo's compartment," he said confidently, stepping out of the crowd to shake Harry's hand." (Rowling, *Prince* 187). Harry also describes his appearance as big and strong as he is "taking note of the breadth of McLaggen and thinking that he would probably block all three goalposts without even moving" (Rowling, *Prince* 187). Since McLaggen could be considered a strong protective male, it might, therefore, seem like Hermione is endorsing traditional gender roles by going to the party with him instead of going on her own. However, Hermione's actions during the party seem to contradict this. When Harry runs into her at the party, she is very relieved to see him and declares "I've just escaped – I mean, I've just left Cormac" (Rowling, *Prince* 263). Furthermore, she also reveals her motivation for going with McLaggen in the first place: "I thought he'd annoy Ron the most," said Hermione dispassionately" (Rowling, *Prince* 263). Thus, she makes it clear that the primary intention of bringing McLaggen is simply to insult Ron and not because she necessarily felt unable to attend the party without a male date. While this may seem like just a minor event in the story at first glance, Hermione's decision to leave McLaggen might symbolise her opposition to traditional gender roles in general. First, she seems to share Harry's view on McLaggen's physical appearance: "Let's go this way, we'll be able to see him coming, he's so tall" (Rowling, *Prince* 263). However, she also describes how "McLaggen makes Grawp look a gentleman" (Rowling, *Prince* 263). By comparing Cormac to the violent, half-giant, half-human brother of Hagrid, she makes it clear that she does not hold him in high regard. Thus, by choosing to distance herself from McLaggen, the strong but also ill-mannered man, she also distances herself from traditional gender roles and

the negative aspects associated with it. Hermione's choice of words to Harry in this moment also seems to suggest that she is undermining patriarchy. At first, she mentions how she "escaped", as if running from a strong oppressing force, but then changes her mind and says "I've just left Cormac". It is as if Hermione realises that she is not afraid of and fleeing from patriarchy but rather choosing to emphasise that she does not agree with its values and therefore stepping away from it, which further showcases her strength as a character.

In conclusion, it is clear that the society of Harry Potter suffers from many issues brought on by the ideas of traditional gender roles. This is seen on many levels, ranging from teenagers like Harry and Ron declaring that women are overemotional lunatics to the leading positions being largely dominated by male characters like Dumbledore and Fudge. Female characters like Umbridge and Hermione, instead have to struggle to keep or even acquire leader roles in the first place. The school of Hogwarts is also affected by traditional gender roles as is clear with teachers like Snape and Umbridge, who seems to view men as naturally more skilled at magic. However, the novels find ways to oppose these values through Hermione's character traits and actions. She shows that women can be just as rational as men and often have to be the rational ones when a male character is acting out of emotion. She also exhibits great leadership qualities and can run an organisation on her own when it is required and thus, is a good example of women being successful leaders as well. While she dedicates a lot of time to her studies in school, she is also not afraid to question the school system even if it was created by "Wizards much older and cleverer" than her as Umbridge states. The strong female character of Hermione Granger demonstrates that, despite traditional gender roles being deeply rooted in any society, it is still possible to strive towards a future where all genders are considered equal.

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